C2 English Vocabulary List (CEFR)

50 words at CEFR C2. Definitions and examples: Wordineer. IPA: CMU Pronouncing Dictionary. Frequency: wordfreq (Zipf, en). Source: wordineer.com/esl-vocabulary-cefr/c2/. License: CC BY 4.0.

Featured cards

debacle · noun · /d■■b■k■l/

A complete and shameful failure

“The launch turned into a public debacle.”

esoteric · adjective · /■■s■■t■r■k/

Known or understood by only a few

“His research covers esoteric parts of physics.”

egregious · adjective · /■■■rid■■s/

Very bad and easily noticed

“The report contained egregious errors.”

ephemeral · adjective · /■■f■m■r■l/

Lasting for a very short time

“Fame can be ephemeral — enjoyed briefly and quickly forgotten.”

echelon · noun · /■■■■■l■n/

A level or rank within an organization

“He reached the top echelon of the firm.”

nadir · noun · /■ne■d■r/

The lowest point of something

“That loss was the nadir of his career.”

zephyr · noun · /■z■f■r/

A soft, gentle breeze

“A cool zephyr moved through the trees.”

cognizant · adjective · /■k■■n■z■nt/

Aware of or knowing about something

“She is cognizant of the risks involved.”

panacea · noun · /■pæn■■si■/

A solution said to fix all problems

“Technology is not a panacea for schools.”

erudite · adjective · /■■r■■da■t/

Showing great knowledge from long study

“The erudite professor spoke five languages.”

sanguine · adjective · /■sæ■■w■n/

Hopeful and positive about the future

“She remains sanguine about the election.”

maelstrom · noun · /■me■lstr■m/

A situation of great confusion or trouble

“The country fell into a maelstrom of protest.”

apocryphal · adjective · /■■p■kr■f■l/

Widely told but probably not true

“That story about the president is apocryphal.”

fastidious · adjective · /fæ■st■di■s/

Very concerned about small details

“He is fastidious about his shoes staying clean.”

bombastic · adjective · /b■m■bæst■k/

Using long words to sound important

“His bombastic speech bored the crowd.”

cacophony · noun · /kæ■k■f■ni/

A loud and unpleasant mix of sounds

“A cacophony of horns filled the street.”

inscrutable · adjective · /■n■skrut■b■l/

Impossible to understand or read

“His inscrutable face gave nothing away.”

recalcitrant · adjective · /r■■kæls■tr■nt/

Refusing to obey or cooperate

“The recalcitrant student ignored the teacher.”

effervescent · adjective · /■■f■r■v■s■nt/

Full of energy and excitement

“Her effervescent laugh fills every room.”

perfunctory · adjective · /p■r■f■■kt■ri/

Done quickly with little care

“He gave a perfunctory nod and left.”

denouement · noun · /■de■■nu■m■n/

The final part of a story where things are resolved

“The novel's denouement surprised every reader.”

ineffable · adjective · /■■n■f■b■l/

Too great to describe in words

“She felt an ineffable joy at her wedding.”

hackneyed · adjective · /■hæknid/

Used so often it has lost meaning

“The film relies on hackneyed jokes.”

quixotic · adjective · /kw■k■s■t■k/

Full of hope but unlikely to succeed

“Her quixotic plan to end hunger inspired many.”

obfuscate · verb · /■■bf■■ske■t/

To make something hard to understand

“The report obfuscates the real numbers.”

surreptitious · adjective · /■s■r■p■t■■■s/

Done in secret to avoid notice

“He took a surreptitious photo of the painting.”

chicanery · noun · /■■■ke■n■ri/

The use of tricks to deceive

“The lawyer accused him of financial chicanery.”

propitious · adjective · /pr■■p■■■s/

Giving a good chance of success; favorable

“The clear skies were propitious for the outdoor ceremony.”

sycophant · noun ·

A person who flatters others excessively to gain advantage

“Surrounded by sycophants, the leader never heard honest advice.”

iconoclast · noun · /■a■■k■n■■klæst/

A person who attacks common beliefs

“The artist was an iconoclast of his time.”

obsequious · adjective · /■b■sikwi■s/

Trying too hard to please someone in power

“The obsequious waiter praised every dish.”

salubrious · adjective ·

Good for your health

“The town has a salubrious mountain climate.”

garrulous · adjective · /■■■r■l■s/

Talking a lot, often about small things

“My garrulous uncle told the same story twice.”

solipsism · noun ·

The philosophical idea that only one's own mind is certain to exist

“His solipsism made it difficult for him to empathize with others.”

desultory · adjective · /■d■s■l■t■ri/

Done without plan or purpose

“He made a desultory attempt at cleaning.”

soporific · adjective ·

Making you feel sleepy

“The long lecture had a soporific effect.”

antediluvian · adjective ·

Extremely old or old-fashioned

“His antediluvian phone still has a cord.”

mellifluous · adjective ·

Sweet and smooth to hear

“She has a mellifluous singing voice.”

limpid · adjective ·

Clear and easy to see through

“The limpid lake reflected the sky.”

truculent · adjective · /■tr■kj■l■nt/

Quick to argue or become violent

“The truculent fan shouted at the referee.”

diaphanous · adjective · /da■■æf■n■s/

Light and almost see-through

“She wore a diaphanous silk scarf.”

pusillanimous · adjective · /pjus■■læn■m■s/

Showing a lack of courage

“His pusillanimous silence angered the crowd.”

copacetic · adjective ·

In good order or completely fine

“After the talk, everything felt copacetic.”

equivocate · verb · /■■kw■v■■ke■t/

To use ambiguous language to avoid commitment or to mislead

“The politician equivocated rather than giving a direct answer.”

lachrymose · adjective ·

Likely to cry or make people cry

“The lachrymose ending made me weep.”

perspicacious · adjective · /p■rsp■■ke■■■s/

Having a ready insight; showing great mental penetration or discernment

“A perspicacious observer noticed the flaw in the argument immediately.”

grandiloquent · adjective · /■ræn■d■l■kw■nt/

Using fancy language to sound impressive

“The mayor gave a grandiloquent farewell speech.”

pellucid · adjective ·

Very clear and easy to follow

“The teacher gave a pellucid explanation.”

vicissitude · noun · /■v■■s■s■tud/

A change in circumstances, often unwelcome

“He faced the vicissitudes of army life.”

defenestrate · verb ·

To throw someone out of a window

“The angry king had his rival defenestrated.”

All C2 words

antediluvian adjective

apocryphal adjective /■■p■kr■f■l/

bombastic adjective /b■m■bæst■k/

cacophony noun /kæ■k■f■ni/

chicanery noun /■■■ke■n■ri/

cognizant adjective /■k■■n■z■nt/

copacetic adjective

debacle noun /d■■b■k■l/

defenestrate verb

denouement noun /■de■■nu■m■n/

desultory adjective /■d■s■l■t■ri/

diaphanous adjective /da■■æf■n■s/

echelon noun /■■■■■l■n/

effervescent adjective /■■f■r■v■s■nt/

egregious adjective /■■■rid■■s/

ephemeral adjective /■■f■m■r■l/

equivocate verb /■■kw■v■■ke■t/

erudite adjective /■■r■■da■t/

esoteric adjective /■■s■■t■r■k/

fastidious adjective /fæ■st■di■s/

garrulous adjective /■■■r■l■s/

grandiloquent adjective /■ræn■d■l■kw■nt/

hackneyed adjective /■hæknid/

iconoclast noun /■a■■k■n■■klæst/

ineffable adjective /■■n■f■b■l/

inscrutable adjective /■n■skrut■b■l/

lachrymose adjective

limpid adjective

maelstrom noun /■me■lstr■m/

mellifluous adjective

nadir noun /■ne■d■r/

obfuscate verb /■■bf■■ske■t/

obsequious adjective /■b■sikwi■s/

panacea noun /■pæn■■si■/

pellucid adjective

perfunctory adjective /p■r■f■■kt■ri/

perspicacious adjective /p■rsp■■ke■■■s/

propitious adjective /pr■■p■■■s/

pusillanimous adjective /pjus■■læn■m■s/

quixotic adjective /kw■k■s■t■k/

recalcitrant adjective /r■■kæls■tr■nt/

salubrious adjective

sanguine adjective /■sæ■■w■n/

solipsism noun

soporific adjective

surreptitious adjective /■s■r■p■t■■■s/

sycophant noun

truculent adjective /■tr■kj■l■nt/

vicissitude noun /■v■■s■s■tud/

zephyr noun /■z■f■r/